Afghans could not leave fast enough; many jumped off the city's walls, its moat filled up with men and animals; others leaped into the river and drowned.[28]

The next day, Akbar mounted his mighty Balsundar and rode into yet another city in yet another outpost of Hindustan that was now his own.

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Daud would lead the Mughals a merry dance for a while yet; it was only in mid-1576, two years after his escape from Patna, that his head would roll at Akbar's feet. But Daud was no longer the point. He was defeated as all who stood in Akbar's path were defeated – eventually, comprehensively, and, as it was beginning to seem, miraculously.

The emperor was on his way back west within a week of Patna's fall. Munim Khan, his old ataliq, a venerable and remarkably fit eighty-years-old,[29] was to lead the pursuit of Daud and the conquest of Bengal. With him went Todar Mal, one of the brightest talents in Akbar's court. Todar Mal was back, recently, from sorting out the revenues of newly conquered Gujarat, but his skills were hardly restricted to accounting; he would also prove himself one of Akbar's best generals.

Akbar, meanwhile, sailed to Jaunpur, where his harem had camped while the emperor was in Patna, and decided to spend a few weeks there. It was a good base from which to keep an eye on the goings-on further east. As Akbar held court at Jaunpur or toured the neighbourhood, news of his presence must have spread. Curious men and women may have come to see if it was true, all that they had heard of him. That he could ride mad elephants with ease, and gallop as fast as the wind, and vanquish rival kings with his mere presence. There must be something special about a man who had held on to the famously slippery throne of Hindustan for almost twenty years. For over half a century – from 1517, when Ibrahim Lodi was crowned, through the entire Suri dynasty and Akbar's forebears – no one had reigned as long.

Akbar had done what other men could not. How much further might his powers extend? One day, in Jaunpur, a delegation of farmers came to the emperor. The rains had stopped before they should have; the farmers feared a famine. They begged Akbar to pray for rain.